

BComm.

INTERVIEW GUIDE



CAREER
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Interview Guide

Congratulations, You Got the Interview!

Getting an interview is a significant achievement. Your resume and cover letter have successfully showcased your qualifications, impressing the prospective employer enough to want to meet you in person (or virtually). Now, it's your chance to confirm your skills and abilities, demonstrate your fit for the role, and learn more about the role and the company. This interview is not only an opportunity for them to get to know you better but also for you to expand on your resume, present your strengths confidently, and evaluate if this position and organization are the right match for your career aspirations. Prepare well, stay positive, and make the most of this exciting opportunity – you're already off to a great start!

Top 10 Tips for a Successful Interview

1. Understand the role: Know the key responsibilities and skills required.
2. Research the company: Understand its mission, values, and recent news. How do your personal and professional values align with the organization's?
3. Prepare answers using the SOAR method to possible questions (p9); share your stories - experience, skills and accomplishments.
4. Anticipate responses to common questions.
5. Develop thoughtful questions about the role and company.
6. Dress appropriately: Choose professional attire.
7. Practice: Conduct mock interviews with CDC career advisors. Record yourself using technology.
8. Plan your journey: For in person interviews, arrive early (10 min). If virtual, test technology and set up (lighting/sound).

9. Bring documents: Have resumes, references, and a notepad.
10. Follow up: Send a thank-you email and reflect on your performance.



DIFFERENT INTERVIEW TYPES & FORMATS

1. Pre-screening Interview (virtual/phone)

The first interview. Commonly used to pre-screen applicants before an in-person interview is scheduled or when the candidate and employer are not located in the same city.

Telephone Interview tips

- Find a quiet location: Minimize background noise.
- Prepare notes: Have your key points and resume at hand.
- Practice speaking clearly: Ensure clarity and pace.
- Listen actively: Don't interrupt and respond thoughtfully.
- Smile: It reflects in your voice.

Video Interview tips

- Test technology - ensure a stable Wi-Fi connection, working camera and microphone and fully charged device.
- Choose a quiet, well-lit space with a professional background.
- Dress like you would for an in-person interview.
- Maintain eye contact - look at the camera, not the screen and remember to smile.
- Prepare notes - have your key points and resume at hand.
- Minimize distractions - silence notifications.



2. **One-on-One Interview** is the most common and traditional interview type where one interviewer meets with one candidate. Can be a mix of interview questions including behavioral, situational, or conversational depending on the skill of the interviewer.
3. **Panel Interview** involves two or more interviewers from different areas of the organization usually taking turns asking questions. Each interviewer may focus on different aspects of the candidate's skills and experience.
4. **Group Interview** is when multiple candidates are interviewed simultaneously. This format assesses teamwork, communication skills, and how candidates perform in group settings. Questions can involve group tasks or individual responses in a group setting.
 - View this as an opportunity to demonstrate your teamwork skills, not a competition!
 - Listen attentively to others and be open to their ideas.
5. **Case Interview** presents candidates with a business problem, situation, or scenario, and requires them to analyze, structure, and solve it within a limited time.

TYPES OF INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

1. **Behavioral Interview questions** focus on how the candidate has handled past situations. The interviewer asks questions based on the competencies required to do the job. These questions assess your experience and are based on the premise that past behavior is the best predictor of future behavior.

Example: "Tell me about a time when you had to lead a team under a tight deadline."

2. Situational Interview questions present hypothetical situations that can occur on the job and asks the applicant how they would handle them. This type of interview question assesses problem-solving and analytical skills.

Example: "What would you do if you were faced with an unhappy customer?"

3. Technical Interview questions assess specific technical skills and knowledge related to the job. Common in fields such as finance, actuary, accounting, data analytics.

Example: "Can you explain the concept of discounted cash flow (DCF) analysis and walk me through how you would use it to value a company."

4. Case interview questions are a critical part of the management consulting recruitment process. The primary goal is to assess the candidate's problem-solving skills, analytical abilities, and how they would approach real-world business challenges that a consultant might face.

Example: "A client's sales have dropped by 20% over the past year. How would you investigate and address this issue?"

PREPARATION IS THE KEY!

Regardless of the type of interview or interview question, the first step to interview success is preparation. Good preparation enables you to:

- Reduce interview anxiety
- Appear confident and professional
- Effectively market your qualifications
- Positively impress the interviewer(s)

How to prepare...

1. Understand the Organization

Find out as much as you can about the organization and its management by reviewing their website, following their social media, and connecting with people you may know who work there.



What to look for...

- What are the mission and values?
- What are their products and/or services, and how are they marketed?
- What is their history, and what are their future plans?
- How many people do they employ?
- Are they international? Where are their other offices?
- What is their reputation?
- How are they structured, and who are the key personnel?

2. Know Who They Are Looking For?

Review the job posting to identify the key skills and qualifications they are looking for. Now, for every skill and qualification they are looking for, assess yourself to see how well you match. Ask yourself:

- What have I learned/gained from previous experience, academic courses and programs, and extracurricular activities?
- What can I offer the employer?
- Why am I interested in this organization/position?
- What type of organizational culture will I be the most successful in?

Before the Interview:

Get Organized and Plan Ahead

1. Prepare and practice answers to common

and behavioral interview questions. This step is extremely important, the more you practice the more confidence you will have! There is more information about interview questions starting on page 6. Remember, you can also attend a workshop or book an appointment for more help or to have a mock interview.

2. Prepare your documents and portfolio with the following:

- Extra copies of your resume.
- Examples of your work.
- List of your references.
- Reference letter(s).
- Transcripts.
- Copy of the job posting.
- List of questions to ask the employer.
- Details including time, location and who you will be meeting with.
- Blank paper and a pen for taking notes.

3. Know where you are going and how you will get there:

- Confirm where you are going, especially if they have multiple locations.
- Check the bus schedule or parking locations.
- Take a trip prior to the interview so you know exactly where to go.
- Plan your departure time so you arrive at least 10 minutes early.

4. Dress for Success!

- Appearance counts - it's part of your first impression! This includes your clothing, hair and grooming. Dress conservatively in clothes that fit well, have been recently cleaned and pressed.
- No cologne, perfume or aftershave. Many companies have "scent free policies" to accommodate sensitivities.
- If you need to purchase an outfit, consider it a worthwhile investment in your future. You might be able to find a great deal at a consignment or thrift store.
- Clothing that is ill-fitted reflects poorly on you as a professional. Save some of your shopping budget to have your outfit professionally tailored to fit you.



- Bright colours and patterns can be distracting, stick with neutral colours for jackets, pants or skirts such as black, grey, blue, beige or brown with a coordinating light shirt, blouse, sweater or tie.
- Make sure you can sit, stand and walk comfortably in what you are wearing. Fussing with your outfit will make you appear less confident/unprofessional.
- If you are unsure or want feedback on your interview attire come see us in room 254!

5. **Go with the flow and be prepared for anything!** You never know what might happen at the interview so even with the best planning, you still need to be flexible and adaptable.
6. **Don't be late!** If something happens, call them ASAP. Never be a no-show. If you've changed your mind about the position, be professional and call them, well in advance of the interview day.
7. **Your interview starts even before you have announced your arrival.** Be kind, friendly and polite to everyone you encounter, you never know who will end up in the interview room with you!
8. **Turn your phone off** and put it away! Take note of your surroundings, you can learn a lot about a company by doing this. You might want to ask questions about your observations... "I noticed a poster recruiting volunteers for an upcoming fundraising event. Can you tell me more about how you support employee volunteerism?"

At the Interview Make a Strong First Impression

Introduce Yourself. Greet the interviewer warmly and confidently. A handshake, when appropriate, combined with a genuine smile,

direct eye contact, and a clear "Thank you for seeing me" is a great way to launch the interview. If a handshake isn't customary or comfortable for you or the interviewer, a polite nod or verbal greeting works well too. Be sure to introduce yourself to everyone who is part of the interview process. To help you remember names, repeat their names back to them and/or write them down on the blank paper in your portfolio. This respectful and inclusive approach sets a positive tone for the interview.

Good body language can help you feel and appear confident. Wait to be invited to sit, then sit tall with your shoulders back and try to avoid fidgeting. Be yourself and use natural hand gestures but avoid excessive movement. Maintain appropriate eye contact; looking directly at the interviewer when speaking or listening demonstrates engagement and confidence.

However, be mindful that cultural differences and neurodivergence can affect body language and eye contact. For instance, in some Indigenous cultures, direct eye contact might be considered disrespectful or uncomfortable. Similarly, some neurodivergent individuals might find maintaining eye contact challenging. If this applies to you, focus on looking at the interviewer's forehead or in their general direction rather than making direct eye contact. The key is to find a balance that shows you are attentive and engaged while respecting your cultural norms and personal comfort.

Listen and respond carefully to the questions asked. Take a moment to think before you respond. Answer clearly and concisely.

Remember, 38% of a first impression isn't what we say, it's how we say it and the tone of our voice. Be positive, never say anything negative about a previous employer, classmate or peer.

Ask for clarification. To ensure you understand the question, don't hesitate to ask for clarification or paraphrase the question to confirm your understanding. Take a brief



moment to organize your thoughts before responding and use a structured approach like the SOAR method to keep your answer clear and focused. Check in with the interviewer to ensure you're addressing the question properly. Having your resume and a notepad in front of you can help you stay on track and provide relevant examples that highlight your skills and experiences.

Show Enthusiasm and Interest - express your interest in the role and the organization. Highlight your enthusiasm for the opportunities the position offers.

Be Honest and Authentic - be yourself. Share your true experiences and strengths. Admit if you don't know something and express your willingness to learn.

Provide an answer to all questions! If they ask you a question that you have not experienced, do your very best to provide an example of a similar situation. If you don't provide an answer they cannot evaluate or score you. Here's an example "Tell me about a time a co-worker wasn't contributing to the team. What did you do?" Perhaps you have not been in this exact situation with a co-worker, but you have been in this situation with a classmate on a group project or a teammate in your sports team.

Always answer "Yes" to "Do you have any questions for us?" Asking well thought out questions demonstrates your sincere interest in the company and position, showing you've done your research. It's also your chance to evaluate if the company is a good fit for you. Prepare four to six questions, as some may be answered during the interview. Have them printed out to ensure you remember them. Generally, stick to no more than three questions. Demonstrate your research by knowing the company's mission, values, and recent achievements, and tailor your questions accordingly.

See page 21 for a list of questions you may want to ask.

Tips for using Generative AI to assist you in preparing for an interview

- Use ChatGPT to simulate mock interviews. Provide it with your resume and job description, and have it generate potential questions. (*****Remember to remove all identifying personal information from your resume before submitting*****).
- Practice answering questions with ChatGPT. It can offer feedback on clarity, tone, and structure.
- Ask ChatGPT to suggest intelligent questions to ask the interviewer based on the company's website, industry, trends, and recent news.
- Use ChatGPT to gather information about the company, its culture, and its recent projects. It can summarize large amounts of data quickly.
- ChatGPT can provide stress reduction through relaxation techniques and tips to manage interview anxiety.

After the Interview: Next Steps

1. **Reflect on the interview, give yourself feedback, and make notes of what you learned.** Right after the interview, jot down what was discussed, and the questions asked. Assess what went well and what could be improved. Consider if there were questions you would answer differently or if you forgot to mention something important. Were you satisfied with your performance? Self-evaluation will help you prepare for future interviews.
2. **Follow-up with the interviewer(s).** Many candidates don't do this, which means they have missed an opportunity to differentiate themselves, reiterate their skills and interest in the job, show their appreciation and mention anything they may have



forgotten in the interview. Don't be this candidate!

A typical follow-up is a thank you email sent within 24 hours of the interview. A handwritten card is also nice but should be dropped off in person to ensure it is received in a timely manner. Your email should include:

- Thanking them for the interview
- Why you are a good fit
- Specifically, why you want to work for them
- Positive closing saying you look forward to the opportunity to join their company

2. **I haven't heard back, what should I do?**

One question you can ask at the end of the interview is "When can I expect to hear back from you?" Their answer will help you know the appropriate time to follow-up. When you follow-up (through email or a phone call) simply ask if you can have an update on where they are at in the recruitment process.

3. **Asking for feedback creates a positive impression and you might learn something.**

Showing that you are open to feedback and want to learn and improve will add to your overall positive impression and you might get some great insight that will help you be successful in future interviews. Some companies have policies that don't allow them to provide feedback, or it might be very general, but it can't hurt to ask!

4. **Networking.** Connect with the interviewer and other company representatives on LinkedIn, expressing your appreciation for the opportunity. This can help keep you on their radar and potentially open other opportunities within the company.

5. **Documenting Lessons Learned.** Keep a detailed record of your interview experiences, including the questions asked,

your responses, and any feedback received. This documentation will be a valuable resource for future interviews, helping you refine your answers and strategies.

Use feedback and reflections to continuously improve your interview skills. Practice answering common questions, refine your elevator pitch, and stay updated on industry trends and company news.

6. **Stay Positive and Patient.** The hiring process can take time. Stay positive and continue your job search while you wait for feedback. Be patient and professional in all your follow-up communications.

By following these steps and thoroughly preparing for your interview, you'll be well on your way to making a great impression and securing the job you want.

Leveraging AI tools for Continued Practice

- **Follow-Ups:** Use ChatGPT to draft follow-up emails and thank you notes. Be sure to add your unique touch.
- **Feedback Analysis:** Input feedback received into ChatGPT to generate suggestions on how to improve.
- **Continuous Learning:** Ask ChatGPT for additional resources or practice questions to further hone your interview skills.

TYPES OF INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

Common Questions & How to Answer Them

These questions are used to determine your interests, motivations, goals, strengths, weaknesses and potential. You should have well prepared and tailored answers to these questions.



Tell me about yourself.

This question helps the conversation get started. Provide the interviewer with a high-level professional overview of who you are and how you are qualified for the position including your education, past relevant experience and extracurricular activities. Add in something unique about yourself to help them remember you.

Tip: Don't assume the person interviewing you has read your resume.

What are your strengths?

Keeping the position in mind, tell them about your strengths and provide relevant examples.

Tip: Prove it! People tend to simply list a bunch of skills, which are meaningless without solid examples to demonstrate how you used them.

What is your weakness?

Select a weakness that is not a key competency related to the job and use this formula to demonstrate how you have improved:

- **W** (weakness) – tell them what it is, but don't spend too much time talking about it.
- **A** (actions) – explain the steps, ideally three, you have taken to improve.
- **R** (results) – provide at least three positive results that have come from your action steps.

Tip: The recruiter cares more about your actions and results than your actual weakness.

Sample Answer: "If I had to choose a weakness it would be my public speaking skills. I wouldn't describe myself as a natural born presenter. I recognize this and I have taken steps to improve by joining the Toastmasters Club at school, making time to practice when I give a presentation in class, as well as researching presentation techniques. As a result, I'm more confident and don't shy away from presenting. My professor commented on my improvement, and I got an A on my last in-class presentation."

What do you know about our company?

Why are you interested in this position?

Why should we hire you?

These are very important questions that could have a significant impact on your interview results. Demonstrating that you have researched and understand the company will prove that you are sincerely interested in the role. These questions help the interviewer determine your "fit" within the team/organization.

Tip: Tell the interviewer how your personal and professional values align with the company's and what is going to motivate you to represent their company.

Handling the "What is Your Salary Expectation?" Question

One of the most challenging questions in a job interview is "What is your salary expectation?" It's important to approach this question with careful consideration, research, and tact. Here are some steps and tips to help you navigate this question confidently and professionally.

1. Do Your Research

Before going to the interview, spend time researching salary ranges for the position you are applying for. Consider the following resources:

- **Online Salary Databases:** Websites like Glassdoor, PayScale, and LinkedIn Salary can provide a range of salaries for specific job titles and geographic locations.
- The [Asper Employment Report](#) available on the website.
- **Industry Reports:** Professional associations and industry reports often publish salary surveys.
- **Network:** Talk to people in the industry, including mentors, career services, and alumni, to get a sense of typical salaries.



- **AI-Powered Salary Tools:** Utilize AI tools like Salary.com's AI-driven salary predictor or LinkedIn Salary Insights, which can provide personalized salary estimates based on your profile and job market trends.

2. Understand Your Value

Reflect on your skills, experience, and education to understand where you fit within the salary range you've researched. Consider:

- **Your Education:** Advanced degrees or certifications can justify higher salary expectations.
- **Relevant Experience:** Internships, co-op programs, and part-time jobs in your field add value.
- **Skills and Competencies:** Specialized skills or competencies can position you at the higher end of the salary range.

3. Consider the Whole Compensation Package

Salary is just one part of the compensation package. Benefits, bonuses, stock options, and professional development opportunities also matter. When negotiating a salary, be prepared to consider other important benefits that add value to your compensation package:

- Health Benefits
- Retirement Plans
- Paid Time Off
- Professional Development Opportunities
- Flexible Working Conditions

Prepare Your Answer

You generally want to defer answering the salary question until you receive a job offer. The longer you can postpone providing a range, the more leverage you will have when it comes time to negotiate your salary – ideally when the employer has determined you are the best candidate and has offered you the position.

When asked about salary expectations, you have several options for framing your response:

- **Deflect Initially:** "I'm more interested in finding a role that fits my skills and career aspirations. I'm confident that if we determine I'm the right fit, we can agree on a fair salary."
- **Turn the Question Around:** "I'm flexible and open to negotiation. Can you share the budgeted salary range for this position?"
- **Provide a Range:** "Based on my research and considering my experience and skills, I believe a salary range of \$X to \$Y would be appropriate. However, I'm open to discussing this further."

Be Confident and Professional. Your delivery is just as important as your answer. Keep these tips in mind:

- **Be Honest:** Don't inflate your expectations unrealistically.
- **Be Flexible:** Show that you're open to negotiation.
- **Be Positive:** Frame your response in a way that shows you're motivated and interested in the position and company.

Practicing your response can help you feel more confident and reduce anxiety. Consider answering the salary question by role playing with friends, family, or career services staff to refine your answer.

Leveraging AI tools for Continued Practice

Utilize AI tools like Interviewing.io or Big Interview, which use AI to simulate interview scenarios and provide feedback on your responses. These tools can help you practice your "salary expectation" responses in a realistic setting and help improve your delivery.

By following these steps and tips, you'll be well-prepared to handle the "What is your salary expectation?" question with confidence and



professionalism. Remember, the goal is to find a mutually beneficial arrangement that reflects your value and fits within the employer's budget.

Behaviour Descriptive Interview Questions & How to Answer

Behavioural-based or behaviour descriptive interview questions are designed to assess your past behavior in specific situations to predict your future performance in similar scenarios, using required competencies. These questions typically start with phrases like "Tell me about a time when..." or "Give an example of..." and focus on power/soft skills such as teamwork, problem-solving, leadership, and adaptability.

Why Employers Use Behavioral-Based Interview Questions

- **To Predict Future Performance:** Past behavior is considered a reliable indicator of future actions.
- **To Evaluate Experience:** Employers can understand better how you have handled real-life situations.
- **To Assess Soft Skills:** BDI questions help interviewers gauge soft skills that are crucial for job performance but not easily measurable through technical questions.

How to Answer Behavioral-Based Interview Questions

To answer a BDI question successfully, you need to tell a specific story, something that happened in the past. Using the **S.O.A.R.** formula will help you structure your answer effectively and tell a compelling story. The S.O.A.R. template:

S = Situation

Briefly describe the context within which you performed a task or faced a challenge. Be specific about when and where this occurred.

O = Opportunity/Obstacle

Explain what you had to overcome or how you made things better by articulating the idea, issue or defining the problem.

A = Action

Detail the specific actions you took to address the task or challenge. Focus on what you did personally, even if it was a team effort. What did you do in this situation? How did you solve the problem? What techniques or skills did you utilize? Include strong action words here like managed, initiated, developed, and analyzed.

R = Results

Share the outcomes or results of your actions. Highlight what you achieved and, if possible, quantify the results to show the impact of your actions (#, \$, %). Many interviewees forget this part of their answer and it's the most important part!

Example of Using the SOAR method:

Interviewer: "Can you give me an example of a time when you had to work as part of a team to achieve a goal?"

Response: "Absolutely. Last semester, I was part of a team in my Organizational Behavior class where we had to complete a group project. The goal was to analyze a company's organizational structure and present recommendations for improvement.

Situation: Our team of five was tasked with analyzing a mid-sized company's organizational structure and recommending improvements. The project had a tight deadline, and we had to present our findings to the class.

Opportunity: As a team, we needed to gather data, analyze the company's structure, identify areas for improvement, and create a comprehensive presentation. My specific role was to lead the data analysis portion and ensure our recommendations were well-supported by evidence.



Action: First, I organized an initial meeting to discuss our strategy and divide tasks based on each member's strengths. I took the initiative to set up a shared document where we could all contribute our findings and track our progress. I then focused on gathering data from various sources, including the company's annual reports, employee surveys, and industry benchmarks.

I ensured open communication by scheduling regular check-ins and encouraging team members to share updates. When we encountered conflicting opinions on some recommendations, I facilitated a discussion to weigh the pros and cons, helping the team reach a consensus.

Result: As a result, we were able to deliver a thorough and well-organized presentation on time. Our analysis was praised for its depth and accuracy, and we received an 'A' for the project. Additionally, the collaborative approach I encouraged helped us work efficiently and strengthened our team dynamics. This experience taught me the importance of clear communication, organization, and the value of leveraging each team member's strengths to achieve a common goal."

This response effectively uses the SOAR method (Situation, Opportunity/Obstacle, Action, Result) to structure the answer, demonstrating this student's teamwork, leadership, communication, and organizational skills.

Examples of BDI Questions

Interviewers design BDI questions to allow candidates to share stories highlighting competencies required to be successful in the role. Examples of BDI questions and the competency required below:

Competency: Stress management

- Tell me about a difficult situation when it was desirable for you to keep a positive attitude. What did you do?

Competency: Time management

- Tell me about a time you had to handle multiple responsibilities. How did you organize the work you needed to do?

Competency: Teamwork

- Tell me about a time when you were working as part of a team and one of the members wasn't contributing. What did you do?

Competency: Customer focus

- Tell me about a time when you had to handle a difficult customer. What did you do?

Tip: The emphasis of your answer (or story) should be on your actions and results. Think about providing three actions and three results for a complete story. So, the formula would look like this S.O.A.A.R.R.R.

Other Types of Questions

In addition to behavioral-based questions, interviewers may use various other types of questions to assess different aspects of a candidate's fit for a role. Here are some additional types of interview questions and examples of each:

1. Traditional Interview Questions

These questions are straightforward and focus on your background, experience, and general qualifications for the job.

- Can you tell me a little about yourself?
- What are your greatest strengths and weaknesses?
- Why do you want to work for our company?



2. Situational Interview Questions

Situational questions present hypothetical scenarios and ask how you would handle them. They assess your problem-solving skills and how you think on your feet.

- What would you do if you were assigned a project with a tight deadline and limited resources?
- How would you handle a situation where a team member is not contributing to a project?

3. Technical Interview Questions

Technical questions are specific to the job and test your knowledge and expertise in a particular area. They are common in fields like finance, actuary, accounting and data analytics.

- Can you explain the difference between accrual accounting and cash accounting?
- How do you perform a financial analysis of a company?

4. Competency-Based Interview Questions

These questions focus on specific skills or competencies required for the job, such as leadership, teamwork, communication, and adaptability.

- Describe a time when you led a team to achieve a difficult goal.
- Give an example of how you effectively communicated a complex idea to a non-expert audience.

5. Brainteaser Questions

Brainteasers and problem-solving questions test your critical thinking, logic, and creativity. They are often used in consulting and tech interviews.

- How many golf balls can fit in a school bus?

- Explain how you would design a coffee machine for astronauts.

6. Case Study Questions

Case study questions present a real or hypothetical business problem and ask you to analyze the situation, develop solutions, and present your recommendations. They are commonly used in business consulting.

- A client is facing declining sales. How would you approach diagnosing the problem and suggesting solutions?
- How would you assess the feasibility of launching a new product in a competitive market?

7. Cultural Fit Questions

These questions assess how well you align with the company's values, culture, and working environment. Employers want to ensure that you will be a good fit for their team.

- Can you describe a work environment where you feel most productive and happy?
- How do you handle working in a team with diverse personalities?
- What type of management style do you enjoy most?"

Motivational Interview Questions

Motivational questions explore your personal drive, career aspirations, and reasons for applying to the specific role and company.

- What motivates you to perform well at work?
- Where do you see yourself in five years?

Stress Interview Questions

Stress questions are designed to test how you handle pressure and challenging situations. They may seem confrontational or unexpected.



- Why do you think you're the best candidate for this job when others have similar qualifications?
- How do you handle criticism?

Closing Questions

Closing questions typically come at the end of the interview and allow the interviewer to address any final concerns or give you the opportunity to ask questions.

- Do you have any questions for us?
- Is there anything else you would like us to know about you?

Illegal Interview Questions and How to Respond to Them

What Are Illegal Interview Questions?

Illegal interview questions are those that employers are not allowed to ask during an interview because they pertain to personal information that is not relevant to the job and can lead to discrimination. In Canada, these questions violate human rights laws that protect individuals from discrimination based on factors such as age, gender, marital status, religion, national origin, disability, and more.

Examples of Illegal Interview Questions

- **Age:** "How old are you?"
- **Marital or Family Status:** "Are you married?" or "Do you have children?"
- **Religion:** "What is your religion?" or "Do you observe any religious holidays?"
- **Nationality or Ethnicity:** "Where are you from originally?" or "What is your ethnicity?"
- **Disability:** "Do you have any disabilities?" or "Have you ever filed a workers' compensation claim?"
- **Gender:** "Do you plan to have children?" or "How do you feel about working in a male-dominated field?"

How to Respond to Illegal Interview Questions Professionally

When faced with an illegal interview question, it's important to handle the situation professionally and tactfully. Here are a few strategies you can use.

Redirect the Question: If asked, "Do you have children?"

Response: "I'm fully committed to my professional responsibilities and managing my time effectively. I'm confident in my ability to meet the demands of this position."

Seek Clarification: If asked, "Where are you from originally?"

Response: "Could you clarify how my background is relevant to the responsibilities of this role? I'm excited to share how my skills and experience can contribute to your team."

Address the Underlying Concern: If asked, "Do you plan to have children?"

Response: "I assure you that I am dedicated to my career and capable of balancing personal and professional commitments. My focus is on contributing effectively to your organization."

Politely Decline to Answer: If asked, "What is your religion?"

Response: "I prefer to keep my personal beliefs private. However, I can assure you that my commitment to my work and my ability to contribute to your team are my top priorities."

Turn It into a Job-Related Response: If asked, "How old are you?"

Response: "I have over [X] years of experience in this industry, and I'm excited to bring my skills and knowledge to your organization."



Tips for Handling Illegal Questions

- **Stay Calm and Professional:** It's important to maintain your composure and respond politely, even if the question makes you uncomfortable.
- **Focus on the Job:** Try to steer the conversation back to your qualifications, experience, and how you can contribute to the role.
- **Know Your Rights:** Be aware of your legal rights and the types of questions that are not permissible. If necessary, you can report the incident to the appropriate authorities after the interview.

By preparing for the possibility of illegal questions and knowing how to respond to them professionally, you can navigate these situations with confidence and maintain a positive impression during your interview.

SAMPLE INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

Below are examples of different types of interview questions based on most common questions, diverse competencies, and industry or major specific questions. However, we strongly advise you to use AI tools to assist you to anticipate questions and prepare responses.

Tips for Generating Sample Interview Questions Using AI

Leveraging AI to generate sample interview questions can help you prepare more thoroughly and diversify the types of questions you practice. Here are some tips for effectively using AI tools like Chat GPT to generate interview questions:

1. Define Your Goals and Context

Clearly define the role you're preparing for, including the industry and specific responsibilities.

- List the key skills and competencies required for the role, such as technical skills, soft skills, and industry knowledge.
- Input the job description into the AI tool.

2. Use Clear Prompts

Provide detailed prompts to the AI tool to generate focused and relevant questions. For example:

- Generate 10 behavioral interview questions for a marketing manager position.
- Create situational interview questions for a customer service representative dealing with difficult clients.

3. Mix It Up

Request a variety of question types, such as behavioral, situational, technical, and cultural fit questions.

- Generate a mix of 15 behavioral, technical, and situational interview questions for a human resource coordinator.

4. Review and Refine

Assess the generated questions and refine the prompts if necessary to get more relevant or specific questions.

- Adjust the generated questions to focus more on teamwork skills and conflict resolution.

5. Simulate a Complete Interview

Ask the AI tool to create a complete set of interview questions, covering all major aspects of the role.

- Create a complete set of 20 interview questions for a sales manager position, including introductory, behavioral, situational, and closing questions.



Example Prompts to Generate Sample Questions

- Generate 10 behavioral interview questions for an entry-level marketing position.
- Create 5 technical interview questions for a software engineer proficient in Python and machine learning.
- List 8 situational interview questions for a customer service representative handling escalated complaint.
- What are 5 questions to assess cultural fit for a collaborative and innovative tech startup?
- Generate 7 interview questions for a digital marketing coordinator in the tourism industry.
- Create a complete set of 20 interview questions for a senior financial analyst position, covering all major competencies.

Example Prompt: “I am preparing for an interview for a marketing coordinator position. Can you generate a mix of 15 interview questions, including behavioral, technical, situational, and cultural fit questions?”

By utilizing these tips and refining your prompts, you can effectively use AI tools to generate a comprehensive and diverse set of sample interview questions tailored to your specific needs.

Below please find further examples of interview questions.

General and Open-Ended Questions

- Tell me about yourself.
- What are your greatest strengths?
- Name one thing about yourself that you would like to improve.

- Describe to me the kind of environment you would like to work in.
- Describe your ideal job. What is the most important thing you are looking for in an employer?
- What have you learned from participation in extracurricular activities?
- Tell me something that you are proud of.
- Tell me about a recent goal you set for yourself.
- What have you learned from your mistakes?
- Tell me about an emerging issue in our profession/industry.
- What would you describe as the biggest responsibility that you have had?
- Tell me something about yourself that’s not on your resume.
- In what ways do you believe you can contribute to our organization?
- I am interviewing 10 candidates all with similar backgrounds today, tell me why I should hire you.
- Why are you interested in working for us?
- Why should we hire you?

Education Focused

- Why did you choose your current program?
- What courses have you liked most? Least?
- What are the main things you’ve learned in your program?
- What is your GPA? Do you think your grades are a good indication of your academic achievement? How would you improve your GPA if you had a chance to do it over again?

Previous Experience

- Why did you leave your previous employer?



- What have you learned from your previous jobs?
- What was the greatest challenge in your last job? How did you deal with it?
- How would your last boss/peers describe you? What did you like most about your last job? Dislike?
- Tell me about a contribution you made at your last job.

Decision Making

- Give me an example of a time you had to make an important or difficult decision. How did you make the decision?
- Describe a specific problem you solved for your employer or professor. How did you approach the problem? What was the outcome?
- Tell me about a time when you had to choose between multiple viable options. How did you evaluate the options, and what criteria did you use to make your final decision?
- Describe a situation where you made a decision that was unpopular with your team. How did you handle the situation, and what was the eventual outcome?

Self-Motivation

- Are you a self-starter? Give me an example.
- How do you stay enthusiastic in your job, despite the parts of it that you don't enjoy or find challenging?

Analytical Skills

- Can you describe a complex problem you faced at work? What steps did you take to analyze the situation and find a solution?
- Describe a project that best demonstrates your analytical skills.
- Tell me about a specific time when you had to analyze information and make a recommendation.

- Describe a situation where your analytical skills helped you identify a potential issue before it became a major problem. How did you handle it?

Teamwork

- Tell me about a time when you were part of a successful work group. What was your role?
- Tell me about a time when you were working as part of a team and one of the members wasn't pulling their weight. What did you do?
- Do you prefer working by yourself or with others? Why?
- Describe the most difficult person you've ever had to work with.
- Describe a time when you put your needs aside to help a co-worker or classmate understand a task. How did you assist them? What was the result?

Leadership

- What characteristics do you feel are important to be a successful leader?
- Tell me about a time when you influenced the outcome of a project by taking on more of a leadership role.
- Give me a specific example of something you did that helped build enthusiasm in others.
- Give me an example of a time you had to persuade other people to act. Were you successful?
- If I asked someone to describe your leadership style, what would they say about you?

Organizational, Time Management & Planning

- Tell me about a time you had to handle multiple responsibilities. How did you organize the work you needed to do? How did you manage your time?



- Tell me about a time when you had to plan or organize something on short notice.
- Tell me about a time you organized an event that was very successful.
- What do you do when you have too many tasks to accomplish in the allowed time?
- Tell me about a time you missed an important deadline.

Communication Skills

- Tell me about a time when you had to present complex information (oral or written) in a way that was clear and easily understood.
- Describe a situation where you were able to successfully convince or persuade someone to do something your way.
- Describe the most significant report or paper that you have written.
- Describe the most significant presentation that you have had to deliver.
- Give me an example of a time when you were able to successfully communicate with another person that you did not get along with.
- What does effective communication mean to you? When have you demonstrated your effective communication skills?

Initiative

- Give me an example of a time when you took initiative rather than waiting to be told what to do.
- Give me an example of a successful project or new initiative you've been involved in.
- Tell me about a time when you went above and beyond to get the job done.
- Give me an example of a time when you initiated a change in process or operations.
- Every job seems to have slow periods. Tell me about a time when you had free time in your last job. What did you do with the free time? What were your co-workers doing? How often did these slack periods occur?

Problem Solving

- Tell me about a time when you had to solve a problem and rules or guidelines were not in place.
- Tell me about a time when you identified a potential problem and resolved it before it became serious.
- Tell me about something challenging you faced in your most recent job; how did you handle it?

Creativity

- Tell me about a time when you came up with an innovative solution to a challenge your company or group was facing. What was the challenge? What role did others play?
- Tell me about the most creative school or work-related project that you have done.

Flexibility/Adaptability

- At one time or another we are all asked to help with something when we don't have the time. Tell me about a recent time when this happened to you and how you handled it.
- Can you think of the last time that you were asked to help on a task that was not directly your responsibility? What was it? What was the situation with your own workload?
- Describe a time or a situation where you had to deal with significant change. How did you handle it?
- Tell me about a time when you had to learn a new skill or technology quickly to complete a task or project. How did you approach the learning process, and how successful were you?

Interpersonal Skills

- Give me an example of a time when your effective interpersonal skills contributed to your success.



- Tell me about a time when you handled a difficult situation with a co-worker. What happened?
- Tell me about a work situation that required you to adapt to a wide variety of people. What was most difficult and what did you enjoy?
- Tell me about a time you built rapport with a difficult customer or client.

Goal Setting/Results Oriented

- Describe two specific goals you set for yourself and how successful you were in meeting them. What factors led to your success in meeting your goals?
- Tell me about an accomplishment that you're most proud of? How did you go about achieving this result? What steps did you take?
- Describe a specific task or assignment you found especially difficult to accomplish. What was it, and what made it difficult?

MAJOR SPECIFIC INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

(please note these are actual questions asked of Asper students)

Accounting & CPA

- Why do you want to be a CPA?
- What do you know about the CPA program?
- Tell me about an emerging issue in the accounting profession.
- You want to compare three companies' financial performance for the past five years. One company is small, one is medium-sized, and one is large. What is a financial technique that accountants can use to overcome this size difference and achieve a meaningful comparison?
- When using ratio analysis to analyze financial statements and company's performance, what are some things to consider?

- You have heard of the terms Financial Accounting and Management Accounting, to be sure. What are some of the differences between the two types of accounting?

Actuary

- Tell me about a current issue facing the insurance industry.
- Tell me about your computer skills. Programs? Level? Examples of where you have used them.
- Can you walk me through a challenging actuarial problem you've encountered during your studies or internship? How did you approach solving it, and what was the result?
- Explain the difference between annuities and life insurance. How does mortality rate relate to both of them?
- Describe your experience with predictive modeling techniques.
- What factors do you consider when determining the appropriate discount rate for a pension plan valuation?
- Actuarial work often involves collaboration with different departments. Can you provide an example of a project where you worked with a diverse team? What role did you play, and how did you contribute to the team's success?

Business Analytics

- How would you describe the role of a business analyst?
- What is your preferred method for presenting data to a group of people?
- When you are given a new project, what do you do first?
- Describe your experience working with large data sets and how you ensure their accuracy.
- How do you ensure your analyses will draw effective insights for the business?



- What tools does a business analyst need to execute their job well?

Consulting

- What do you think are the attributes of a successful consultant?
- Can you describe a project from your academic or internship experience where you had to analyze data to provide recommendations? What was your approach, and what impact did your recommendations have?
- Management consulting often involves working with diverse teams and clients. Can you give an example of a time when you had to collaborate with others to achieve a goal? What role did you play, and what was the outcome?
- Consultants often need to adapt to new industries and business environments quickly. Can you provide an example of a time when you had to learn something new rapidly? How did you approach the learning process?

Entrepreneurship

- How are you going to market your product or service?
- Describe a situation where you demonstrated creativity or innovative thinking to solve a business challenge.
- As an entrepreneur, how do you deal with uncertainty and risk? Provide an example.
- Have you ever developed a business plan, and if so, what key components did you include?
- How did you come up with your business idea?
- What are your strengths and advantages over your competitors?
- What excites you most about entrepreneurship, and why did you choose this career path?

- How do you maintain your passion and commitment during challenging times in a business venture?

Finance

- What enticed you to apply to a position at our bank?
- What do you think a finance analyst does?
- Do you follow the market? Share your thoughts with me.
- Do you have any investments? In what? Why?
- How do you feel the market will turn out at fiscal year end?
- Where would you invest given the current market conditions and why?
- Can you tell me the stock price of any company off the top of your head?
- What stocks do you follow? Why?
- Tell me how you would value a company? If you could use only one statement to review the overall health of a company, which statement would you use, and why?
- Can you explain the difference between equity and debt financing?
- How would you measure a company's financial health?
- How would you determine the discount rate?
- What is the exchange rate today?
- Tell me about a time when you used financial data to prove a point.
- What is a hedge fund? What is a bond?
- Explain the concepts of cash flow and net income.
- Name three well known investment banking firms.
- Give me an example of a calculated risk you have taken. What was the result?

Investment Banking

- Tell me about a current issue in the banking industry. How do you think this issue impacts investment decisions, and what strategies would you recommend to mitigate any negative effects?



- Why do you want to be an analyst/investment banker?
- Can you describe a time when you conducted a detailed financial analysis on a company or industry? What was your process, and what key insights did you uncover?
- Why would you make a good investment banker?
- How do you stay informed about market trends and economic indicators that impact investment decisions? Can you provide an example of how this knowledge could influence an investment recommendation you might make?
- What, in your opinion, are the key ingredients in building and maintaining successful business relationships? Give me examples of how you have made these work for you.

Human Resources

- What do you think are the key qualities for human resources professionals?
- What is employment equity?
- What is workers compensation?
- How do you stay current with your knowledge of human resources regulations and best practices?
- Do you have any experience directing inclusion and diversity-based conversations?
- What are the steps in processing a suspension or termination of an employee?
- What are the components of an effective performance review program?
- What tools do you use in determining the salary for a position?
- What is a grievance and describe a grievance process.
- What can you tell me about the employment market right now? In Winnipeg or Canada?
- Do you have any experience with using social media for recruiting purposes?
- How would you address the issue of workplace harassment or discrimination?
- Can you tell me what Behavior Descriptive Interview questions are?
- Can you give me an example of an illegal interview question?
- Name one emerging issue in the human resource management field.
- What made you consider human resources as a career?

Indigenous Business

- What are your experiences building relationships with Indigenous peoples and communities? Describe the ways you have built and maintained relationships.
- Tell me about the 3 differences in tax on reserves and how does this impact the financing of Indigenous businesses on reserve?
- Describe the key points of Call to Action #92, where do you see your abilities to contribute to advancing truth and reconciliation in business?
- Imagine you are tasked with facilitating a meeting between your consulting team and the First Nation Chief and Council. One of the key cultural differences you need to consider is the approach to decision-making. The Chief and Council have a consensus-based decision-making process deeply rooted in their cultural values, while the consulting team typically follows a more hierarchical decision-making structure. How would you approach this situation to ensure effective collaboration and respect for their cultural norms?
- How would you approach a band/nation with a business or economic development opportunity?
- How are you going to enact/enshrine sustainable business practices into your business operations when working in collaboration with Indigenous communities?

**Marketing**

- Tell me the difference between advertising and marketing.
- What aspect of marketing are you the most interested in and why?
- Provide an example of how you used your creativity and resourcefulness to meet a tough challenge.
- What experience do you have with digital marketing platforms?
- If you had a new product and wanted to arrange for shelf space in a national chain, how would you do this?
- What are the most important questions you need to ask before beginning to plan a marketing/advertising campaign?
- What do you think about our advertising campaign for _____ product?
- Tell me about a marketing program that you initiated at school or work.
- What was your favourite product launched in the last few years? What did you like about it?
- Give me an example of a good (bad) marketing campaign you've seen. What did you like (dislike) about it?

Sales and Business Development

- Sell me this pen.
- Tell me about the nicest compliment that you have received from a client/customer.
- What attracts you to the _____ industry?
- How would you go about identifying new prospects?
- What strengths do you feel are important in being successful in sales?
- How do you keep yourself positive and motivated for selling?
- Provide an example of when you received a 'no' from a customer and later turned it into a 'yes'.

- What were your sales goals in your past sales job? How did you perform?
- Tell me about the most difficult or challenging sale that you have made.
- Can you tell me about a time when you went beyond the customer's expectations to meet their needs?
- Can you share a specific example of a time when you identified and seized upon a business opportunity?
- Which competitor is doing the best job and why?

Strategy and Global Management

- How would you handle cultural differences when working with global teams?
- How would you ensure that a company's values and ethics are upheld across all international operations?
- What role does corporate social responsibility (CSR) play in international business?
- How would you build relationships with key stakeholders in foreign markets?
- How do you stay updated on international trade regulations?
- How do you assess potential risks and opportunities in foreign markets?
- What strategies will you employ to minimize political risk in international business operations?

Supply Chain Management & Logistics

- What are some of the challenges faced in supply chain management today?
- What is the role of inventory management in supply chain management?
- What is the role of accurate forecasting in supply chain management?
- How would you evaluate and select suppliers in supply chain management?
- What are the key factors to consider when selecting a transportation mode for a supply chain?



- What are some challenges in managing global logistics and transportation?
- Tell me about a time when you had to identify a problem within a supply chain and implement a solution. What was the problem, and what steps did you take to solve it?

Questions to Ask the Interviewer

Always ask questions! We recommend preparing 4-6 before your interview based on research and your curiosity to learn more about the role and the company. Here are some great example questions from TheMuse.com.

The Job

- What does a typical day look like?
- What are the most immediate projects that need to be addressed?
- What are the skills and experiences you're looking for in an ideal candidate?
- What attributes does someone need to have to be successful in this position?
- What are the biggest challenges that someone in this position would face?
- Is this a new role that has been created?
- Do you expect the main responsibilities for this position to change in the next six months to a year?

Training and Development

- What training programs are available to your employees?
- Are there opportunities for advancement or professional development?
- Where have successful employees previously in this position progressed to?

Performance Management

- What are the most important things you'd like to see someone accomplish in the first 30, 60, and 90 days on the job?
- What are the performance expectations of this position over the first 12 months?

- What is the performance review process like here? How often would I be formally reviewed?
- What metrics or goals will my performance be evaluated against?

The Company

- I've read about the company's founding, but can you tell me more about ____?
- Where do you see this company in the next few years?
- What can you tell me about your new products or plans for growth?
- What are the current goals that the company is focused on, and how does this team work to support reaching those goals?
- What gets you most excited about the company's future?

The Team

- Can you tell me about the team I'll be working with?
- Who will I work with most closely?
- Who will I report to directly?
- Can you tell me about my direct reports? What are their strengths and the team's biggest challenges?
- Do you expect to hire more people in this department in the next six months?
- Which other departments work most closely with this one?
- What are the common career paths in this department?

Company Culture

- What is the company and team culture like?
- How would you describe the work environment here—is the work typically collaborative or more independent?
- Can you tell me about the last team event you did together?
- Is there a formal mission statement or company values? (Note: Make sure this isn't Google-able!)
- What's your favourite office tradition?
- How has the company changed since you joined?



Next Steps

- Is there anything that concerns you about my background being a fit for this role?
- What are the next steps in the interview process?
- Is there anything else I can provide you with that would be helpful?
- Can I answer any final questions for you?

Final Words

Congratulations on taking the time to review this interview guide.

Remember, the key to a successful interview lies in thorough research and preparation. By understanding the company, the role, and how your unique skills and experiences align with the opportunity, you position yourself as a confident and compelling candidate.

Approach each interview with a proactive mindset, ready to showcase your strengths and engage thoughtfully with your interviewers. Your dedication to preparing will set you apart and pave the way for your next career achievement.

Best of luck in your interview journey – you’ve got this!



